

Team,

As we prepare for more direct client interactions, I want us to focus on one important skill:

Communicating clearly and confidently with different types of stakeholders.

I have noticed that we are often able to provide accurate technical information, but sometimes we can be hesitant to speak up, explain our thinking, or adapt the way we communicate depending on who we are speaking with.

To help with this, our next session will include a practical communication exercise.

The Exercise

Each of you should come prepared with **one recent technical update** from your work.

This could be:

- A bug that was fixed
- A feature that was completed
- A deployment that was delayed
- A technical issue that is currently being investigated
- A blocker or dependency
- Any other recent project update

You will then communicate **the same update to three different stakeholders**. The important part is that the information itself does not change.

The way you communicate it should change depending on the person you are speaking with.

Your goal is to practice:

- Choosing the right level of technical detail
- Explaining technical information in simple business terms
- Adjusting your tone and level of formality
- Speaking clearly and confidently
- Getting to the important information quickly
- Responding appropriately to the stakeholder's communication style

Stakeholder 1 – Your Technical Teammate

Imagine you are speaking with another team member who is working closely with you on the same project.

This person understands the technology, the project terminology, and the technical challenges.

For this conversation:

- You can use technical terminology and common acronyms.
- You can discuss implementation details.
- You can talk about code, APIs, environments, dependencies, blockers, etc.
- Focus on what happened, why it happened, and what needs to happen next.
- Keep the conversation collaborative and natural.

Think:

"I am speaking with someone who already understands the technical context."

Stakeholder 2 – A Non-Technical Business Owner

Now imagine that the same update needs to be explained to a business owner who has no technical background.

They are interested in the **business impact**, not how the technology works.

For this conversation:

- Avoid technical jargon wherever possible.
- Explain the situation in simple language.
- Focus on what happened and what it means for the business or end user.
- Explain any impact on timelines, delivery, priorities, or expectations.
- If there is a problem, clearly explain what the problem means and what you are doing about it.
- Do not assume that the stakeholder understands technical terminology.

For example, instead of explaining *how* a technical problem occurred, explain **what the problem means for the customer and what the team is doing to resolve it**.

Think:

"If I cannot use technical terminology, how would I explain this clearly?"

Stakeholder 3 – A Busy, Fast-Paced Client

For the third scenario, imagine that you are speaking directly with a busy client or senior stakeholder who has limited time.

They want to understand the situation quickly and know whether they need to be concerned.

For this conversation:

- Start with the most important information.
- Be concise and structured.
- Communicate the current status clearly.

- Explain the impact.
- Clearly state what happens next.
- Avoid unnecessary background information.
- Speak confidently rather than apologetically.
- If the stakeholder is speaking quickly, practice keeping up with the pace while still maintaining clarity.

Think:

"If this person only gives me 30 seconds, what are the three most important things they need to know?"

What I Want You to Practice

The exercise is not only about changing the words you use.

Pay attention to **how you communicate**.

1. Vocabulary

Ask yourself:

Who am I speaking to, and how much technical knowledge do they have?

Can you communicate the same information using technical terminology with one person and simple business language with another?

2. Tone

Consider the situation and the stakeholder's temperament.

Are they:

- Relaxed and conversational?
- Stressed about a problem?
- Focused on deadlines?
- Asking for details?
- Looking for a quick answer?

Your tone should help the conversation rather than add to the tension.

3. Pace

Pay attention to how quickly the stakeholder is communicating.

Practice:

- Slowing down when clarity is more important than speed.
- Speaking at a natural pace when explaining something complex.
- Being concise when the stakeholder is pressed for time.
- Avoiding rushing simply because the other person is speaking quickly.

The goal is **not to imitate someone's accent or nationality**. The goal is to recognize their communication style and adjust appropriately while keeping your own speech clear and professional.

4. Confidence

Most importantly, practice **speaking up**.

Do not worry about having the perfect wording.

You should be comfortable saying things such as:

- "The main issue is..."
- "The impact is..."
- "What we have done so far is..."
- "Our next step is..."
- "The main blocker at the moment is..."
- "My recommendation would be..."
- "Let me clarify that..."
- "I don't have that information yet, but I will confirm it."

Being confident does not mean knowing everything. It means being comfortable communicating what you know, what you don't know, and what you are going to do next.

What to Prepare

Before our next session, please have **one recent technical update** ready. You do not need to prepare three completely different updates.

Prepare **one update and think about how you would communicate that same information to each of the three stakeholders**.

During the session, you will have the opportunity to practice each scenario and receive feedback. This is a safe space to experiment, make mistakes, and try different communication styles.

The purpose is not to test your technical knowledge, it is to help you become more comfortable **speaking, explaining, and adapting your communication** before doing this with live clients.

Please come prepared to participate and try the exercise. If you have any questions before the session, let me know.

Looking forward to working through this with everyone.

Thank you all!